SeeWandel Climate

Interreg
Alpenrhein-Bodensee-Hochrhein

Kofinanziert von der Europäischen Union

Regime Shifts in Plankton Dynamics: What Drives Them and Can We Predict Them?

Dr. Leonardo Capitani
Department of Aquatic Ecology, Eawag · SeeWandel-Climate

www.seewandel.org

Ecomeets @ Eawag, Dübendorf
28 October 2026

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The Pomati lab



Pomati lab
Plankton Ecology, Eawag

SeeWandel-Climate
Lake Constance

Take home message

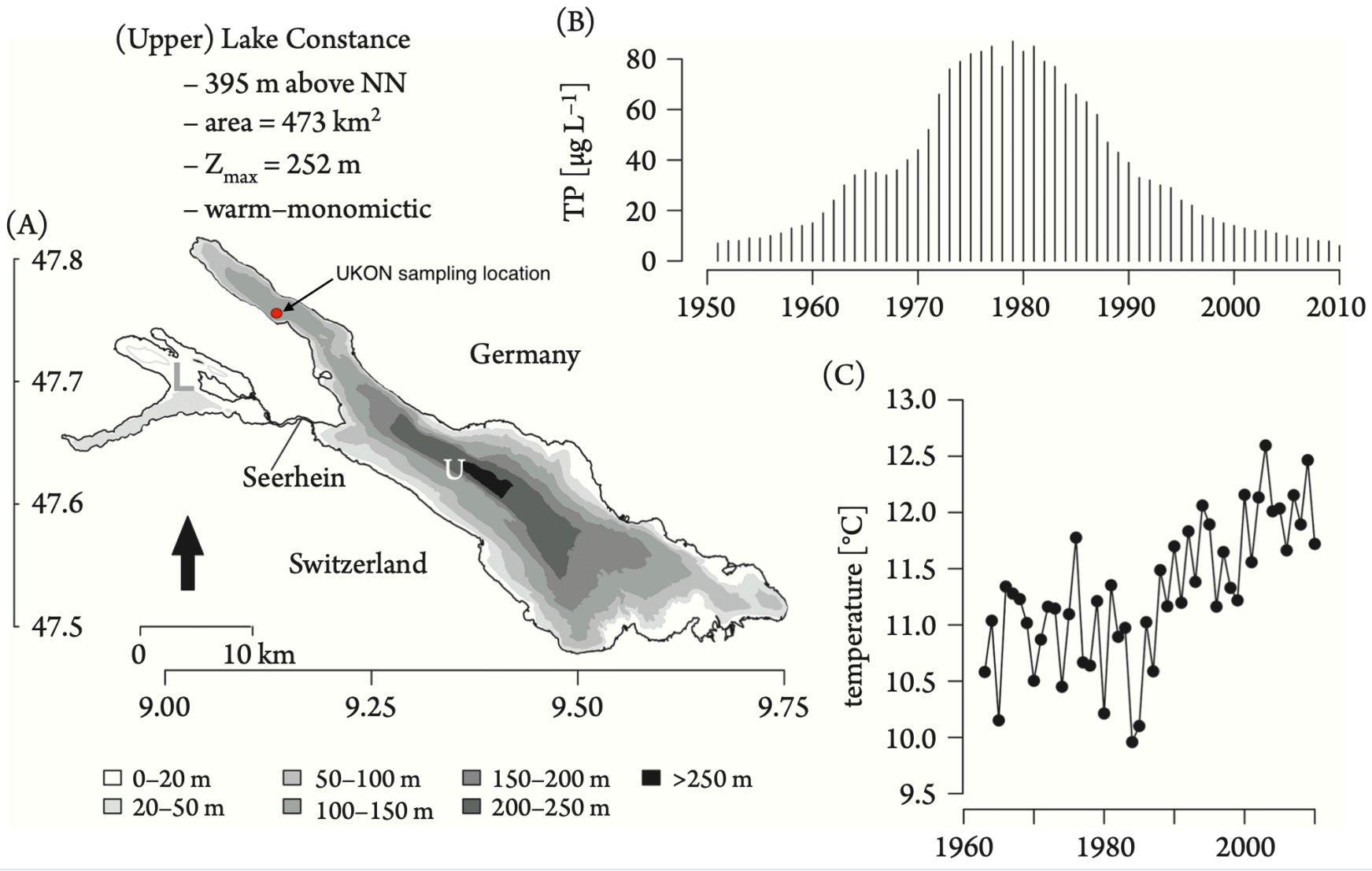
Plankton regime shifts can be detected and partly explained by biotic drivers. Whether they propagate and can be predicted is still open.



Outline

1. What we know: background
2. Research questions
3. Methods: our pipeline
4. Results: detection of regime shifts
5. Explain regime shifts
6. Propagation of regime shifts
7. Conclusions

What we know: background

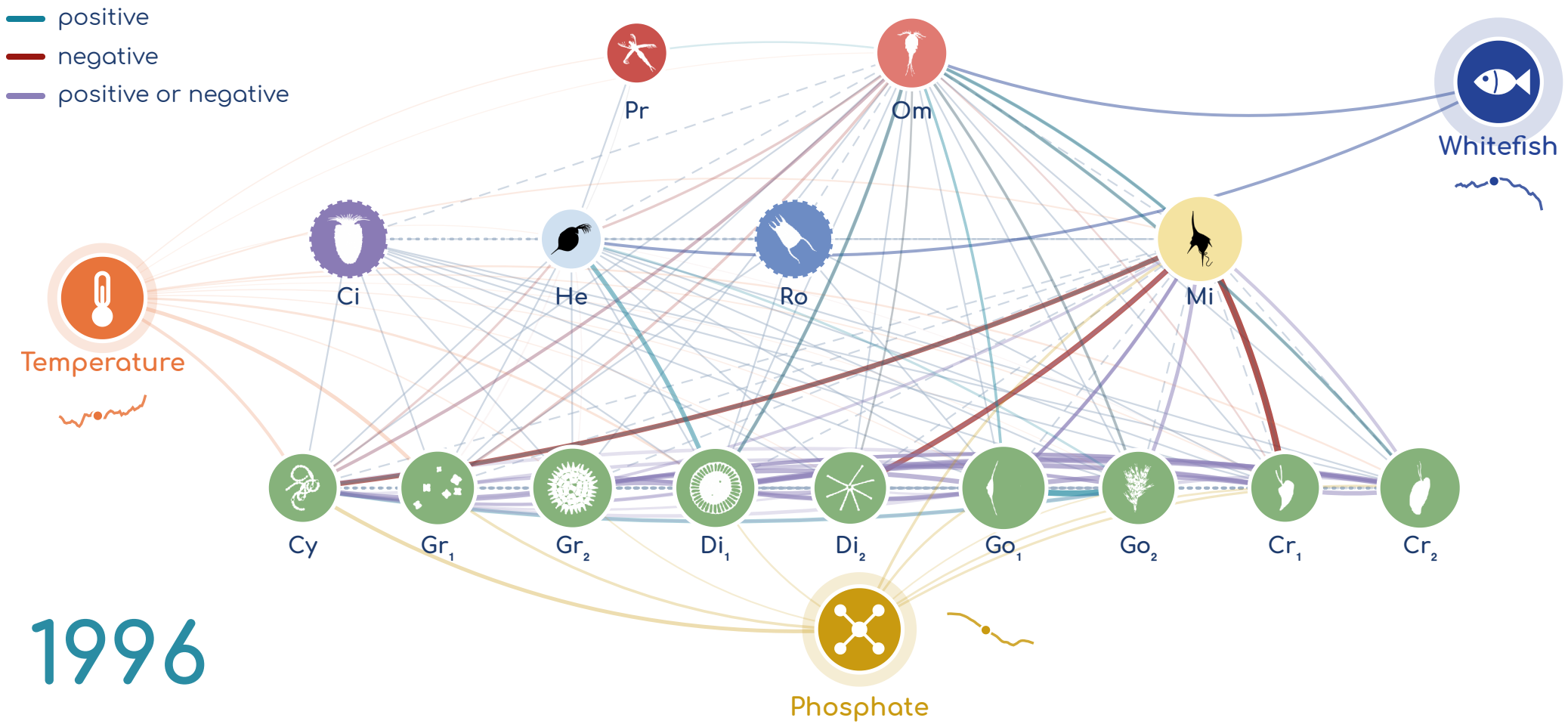


Lake Constance
473 km² · 252 m deep

Phosphate ↑ until 1980, then ↓

Temperature ↑ about 1 °C

What we know: the plankton community



The plankton community changes across time

Network modified from Merz et al. 2023, Nat. Clim. Change.

Research questions



1 · Detect

Abrupt shifts?



2 · Explain

What drives them?



3 · Propagate

Does a shift spread?



4 · Predict

Can we forecast them? (in progress)

Methods: our pipeline

1

Data

Monthly data 1975–2022

2

Detect

BEAST + two criteria

3

Explain

GP-EDM + hypotheses

4

Propagate

Shift-removal test

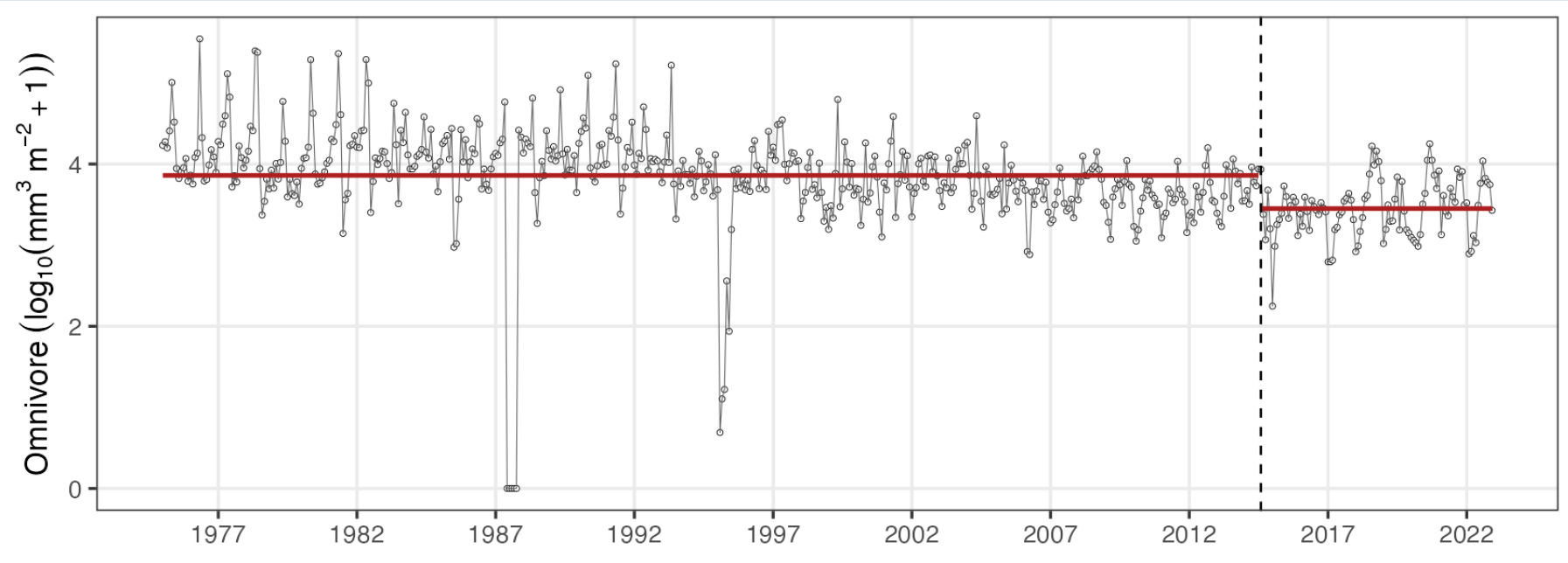
5

Predict

Forward validation

WORK IN PROGRESS

Results: detection of regime shifts





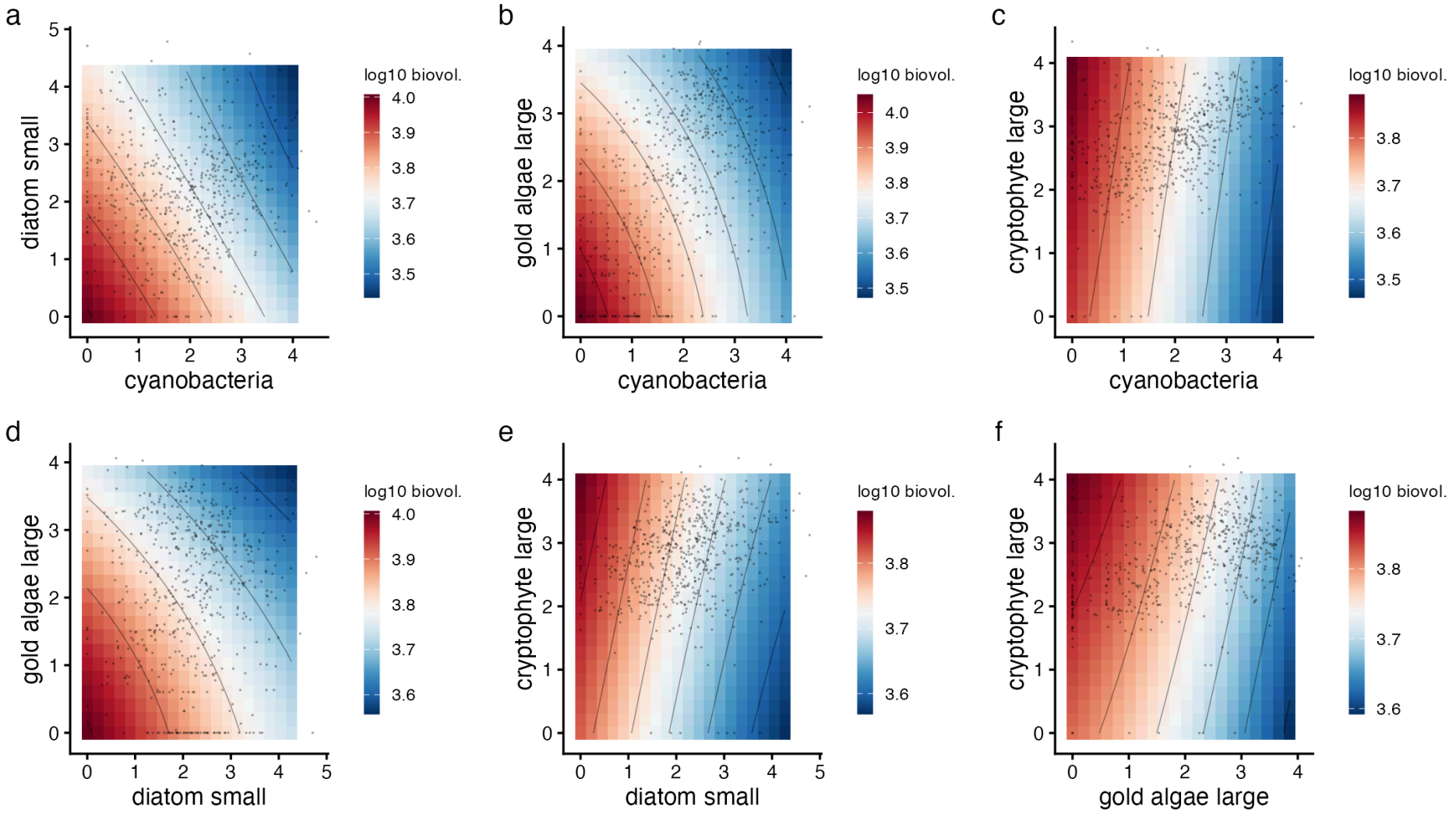
Shift: Aug 2014

abruptness 1.19

Omnivores, monthly biovolume. Dashed: shift; red: period means.

The omnivores dropped abruptly in 2014

Explain regime shifts



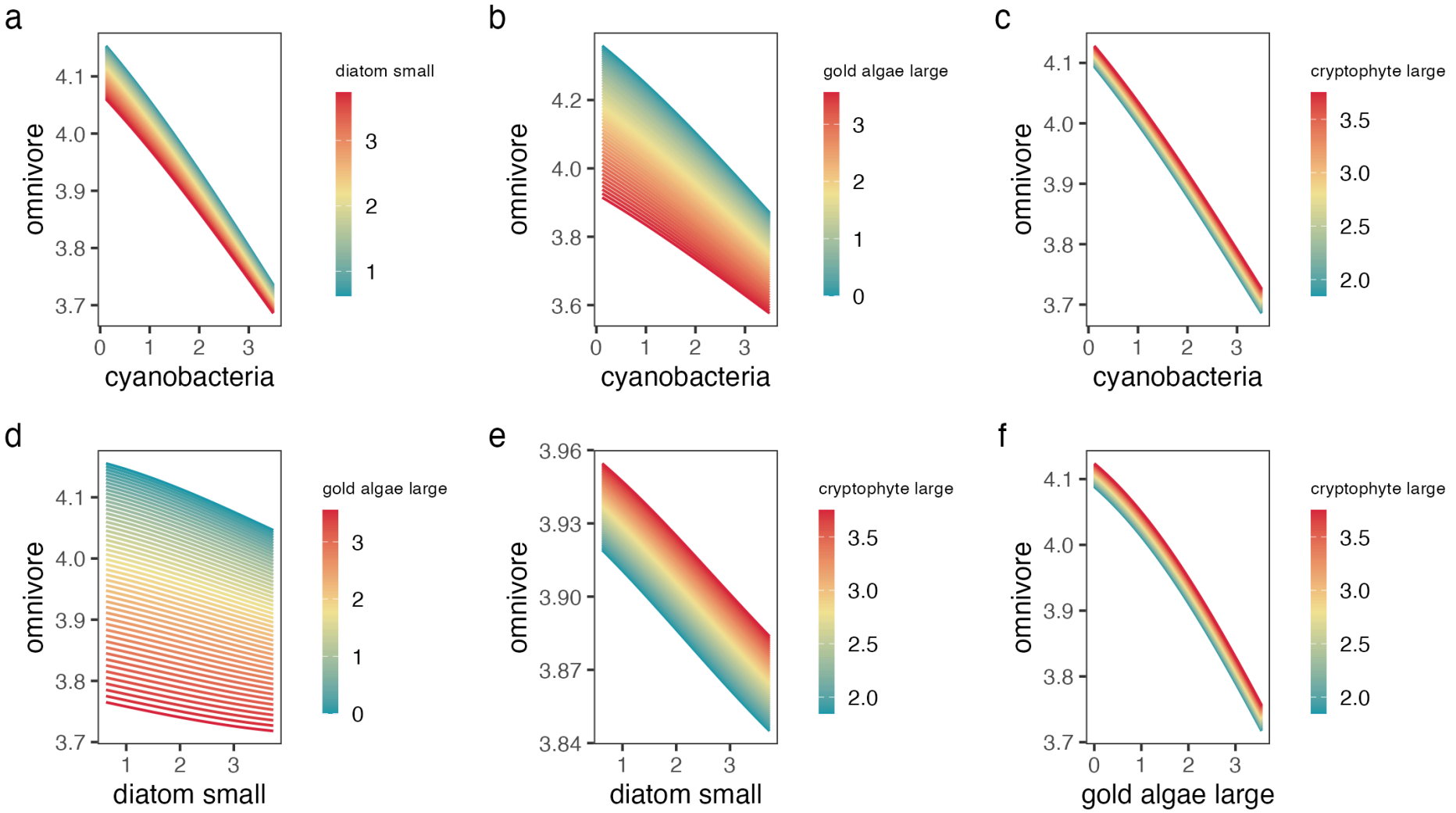


LOO R^2 = **0.81**

Omnivores ↓ with cyanobacteria, small diatoms, large gold algae

Prey hypothesis: **not supported**

Explain regime shifts: partial dependence





x: predictor 1
lines: predictor 2

Cyanobacteria ↓ omnivores

Lines never cross

Propagation of regime shifts

1 · Real predictor



2 candidate pairs

0 testable

Predictor shifted **after**

2 · Shift-free surrogate (× 100)



Gap between real and surrogate prediction = evidence for propagation

No evidence yet: too few shifts

Conclusions



Shifts are detectable



Biotic drivers matter



Propagation, prediction: open

Take home message

Plankton regime shifts can be detected and partly explained by biotic drivers. Whether they propagate and can be predicted is still open.



Acknowledgments

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Kofinanziert von der Europäischen Union

igkb
Internationale Gewässerschutzkommission für den Bodensee

IBKF

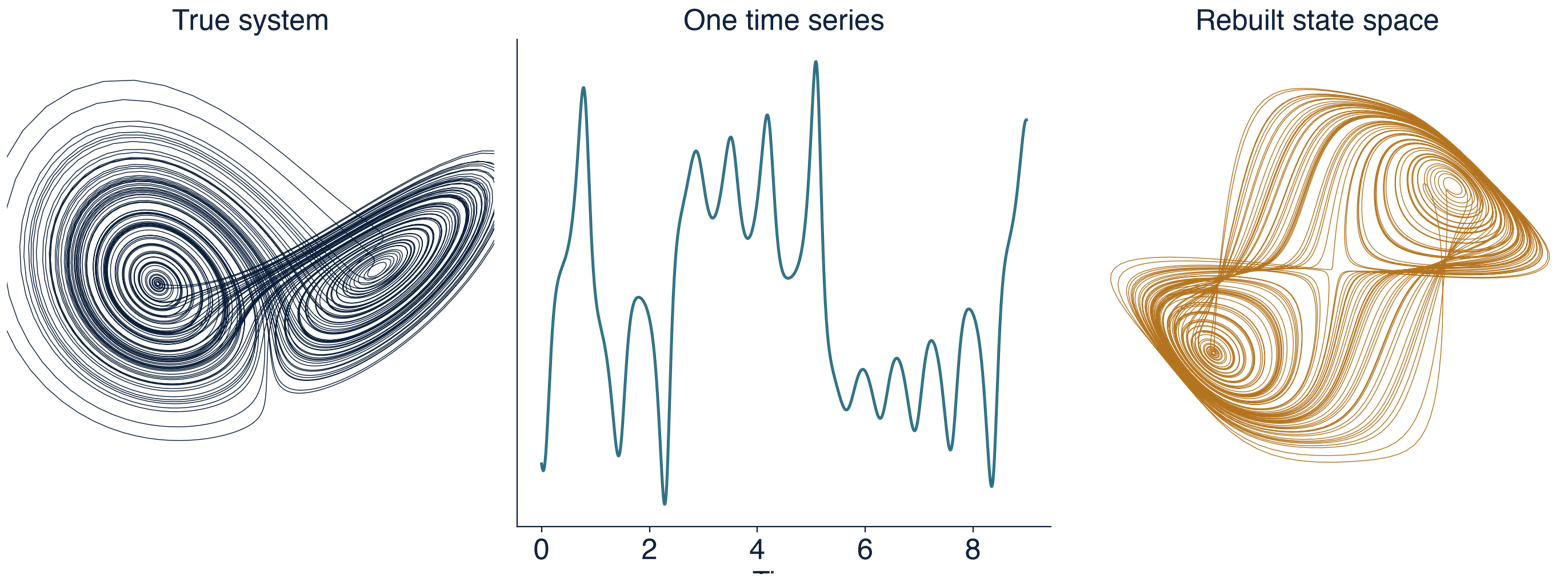
SeeWandel-Climate · Pomati lab and colleagues at Eawag
Luis J. Gilarranz · Stefanie Eyring · Stephan B. Munch · Tanya L. Rogers · Francesco Pomati
Data: IGKB, IBKF, University of Konstanz (D. Straile)

Supplementary material

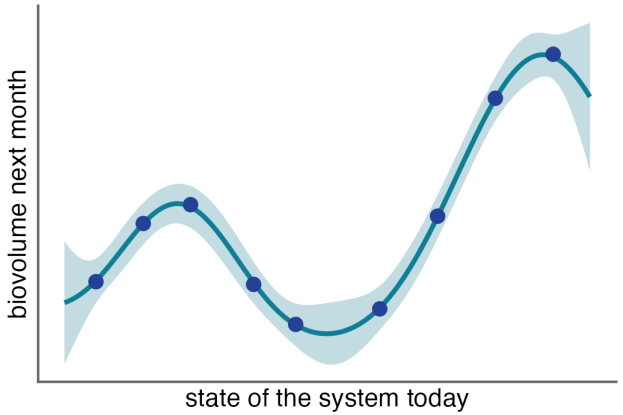
Methods in detail



What is GP-EDM?



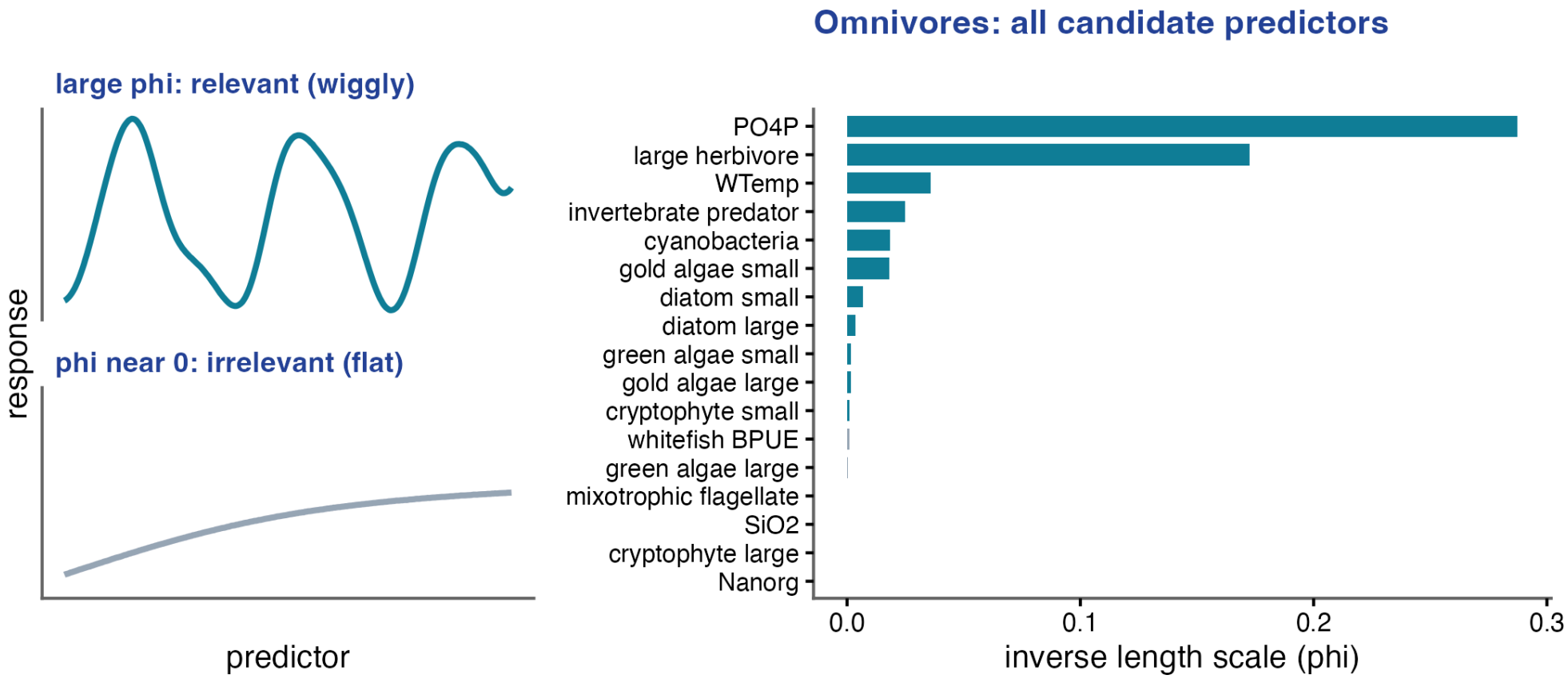
Gaussian process: no fixed equation



Next month = f(past states, drivers)

f learned from the data: Gaussian process

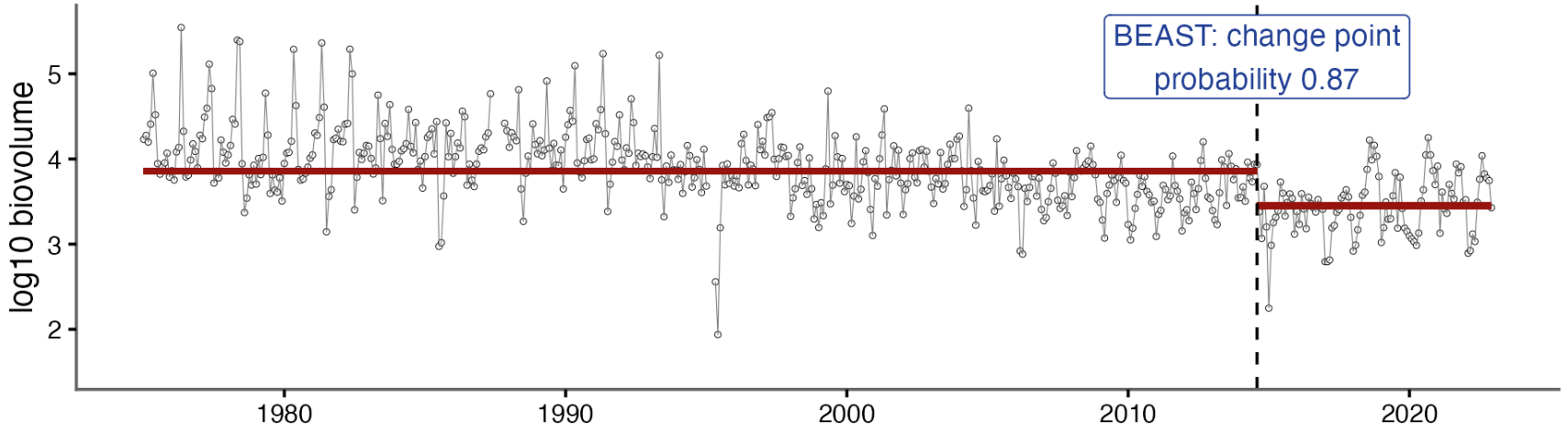
Automatic relevance determination (ARD)



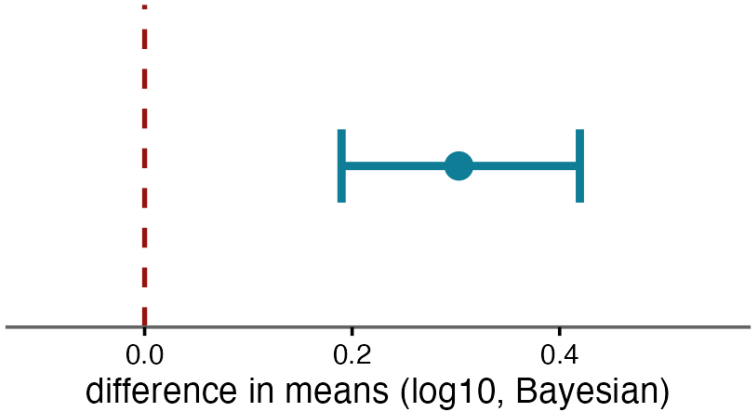
One length scale per predictor: **phi near 0** = predictor dropped

Detecting regime shifts: BEAST and two criteria

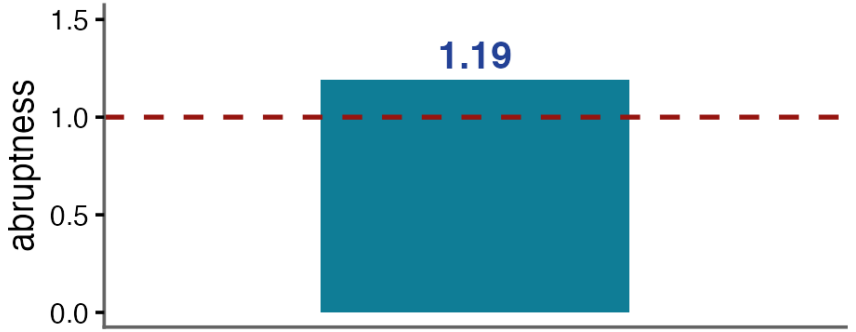
1: Candidate: BEAST change point



2: 95 % interval excludes 0



3: Abruptness > 1



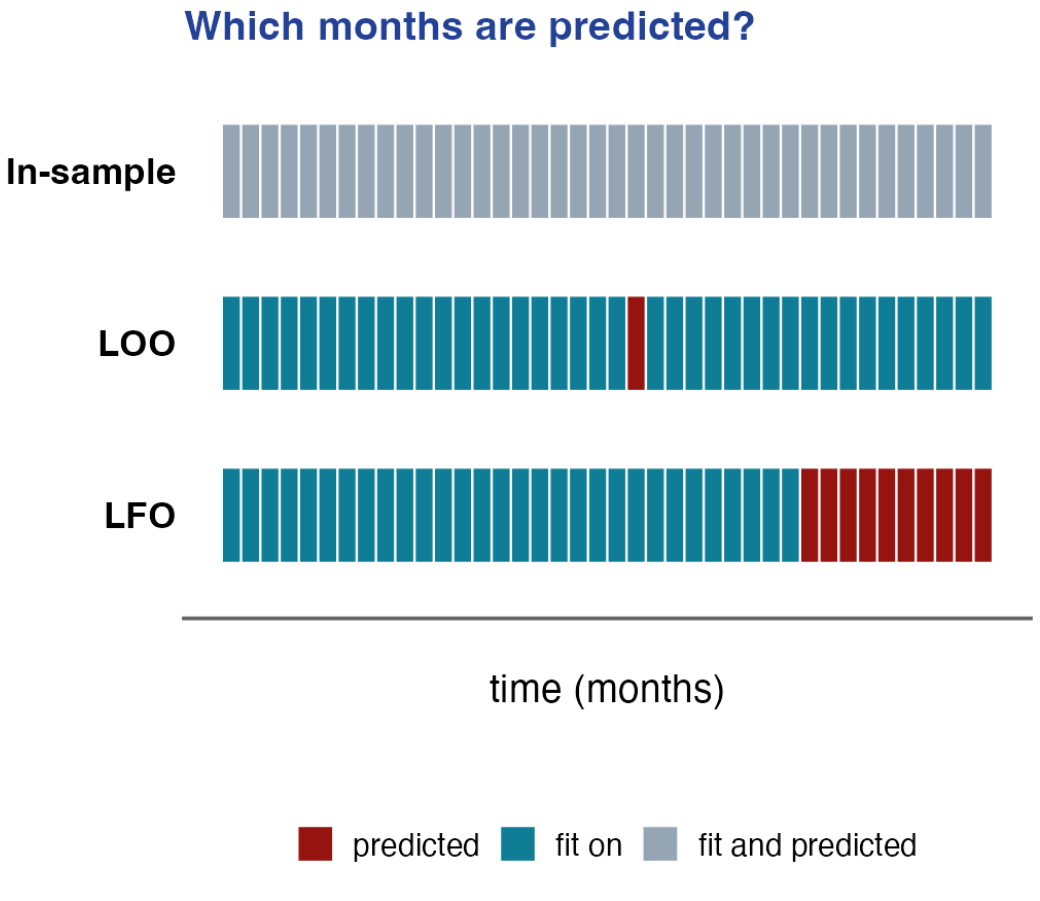
Kept if **both** hold

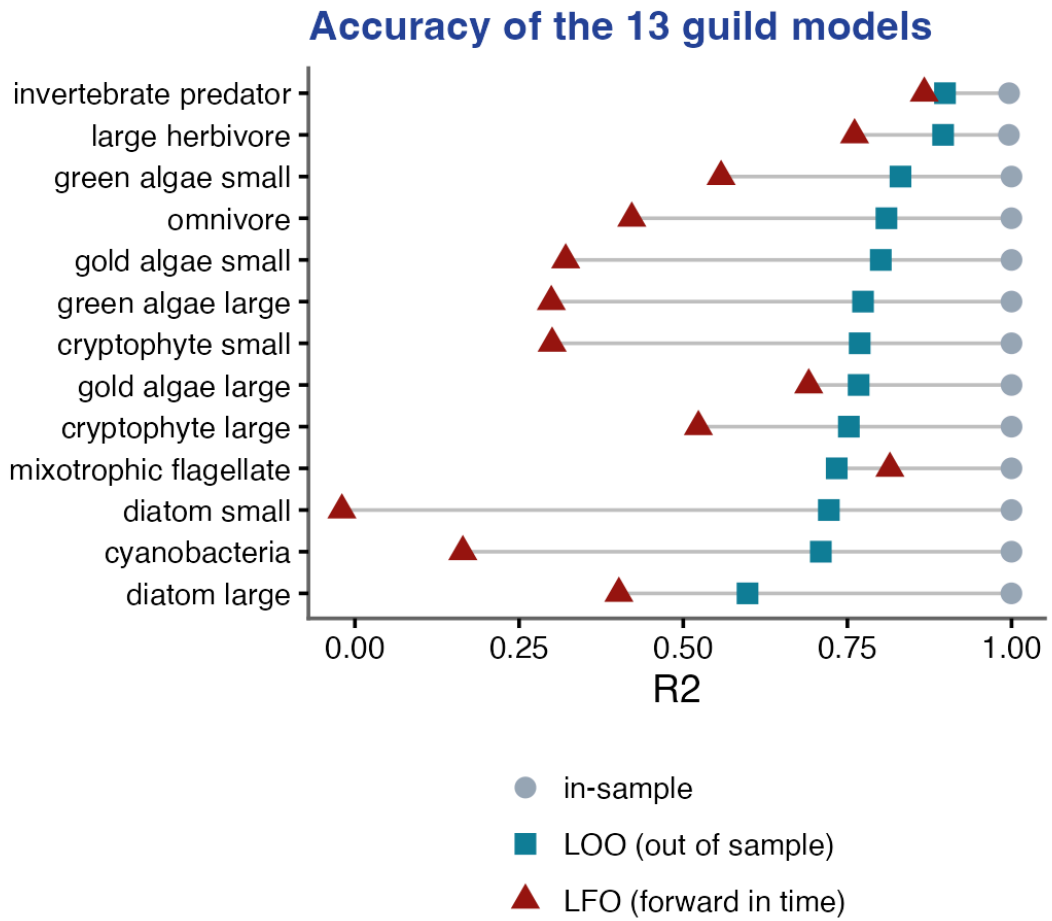
2 interval excludes 0

3 abruptness > 1

abruptness = |difference| / mean SD of the two periods

In-sample versus out-of-sample R^2





In-sample: $R^2 = 1$, a GP interpolates

LOO: one month left out

LFO: forecast the last 10 %

Which genera? Zooplankton and mixotrophs



Invertebrate predators

Pr

Leptodora	73%
Bythotrephes	27%



Omnivores

Om

Cyclops	80%
Mesocyclops	17%
Acanthocyclops	1%
Thermocyclops	1%
Asplanchna	0%

+ 4 more



Large herbivores

He

Daphnia	91%
Eudiaptomus	6%
Bosmina	2%
Diaphanosoma	1%
Acanthodiaptomus	0%

+ 6 more



Mixotrophic flagellates

Mi

Ceratium	46%
Gymnodinium	45%
Peridinium	7%
other Flagellaten	1%
other Phytoflagellaten	0%

+ 14 more

Top genera by share of biovolume, IGKB 1975–2022

Which genera? Phytoplankton (1/2)



Cyanobacteria

Cy colonial

Anabaena	44%
Aphanizomenon	16%
Planktothrix	9%
Cyanothece	7%
Aphanothece	6%

+ 25 more



Green algae, small

Gr1 ≤ 550 µm³

Volvocales	30%
unidentified algae	24%
Chlorella	21%
Oocystis	7%
Characium	3%

+ 21 more

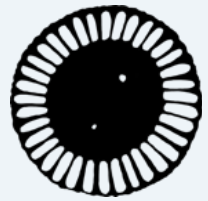


Green algae, large

Gr2 > 550 µm³ or colonial

other Chlorococcales	23%
Pandorina	18%
Mougeotia	16%
Chlamydomonas	10%
Ulothrix	6%

+ 46 more

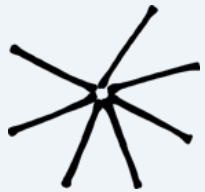


Diatoms, small

Di1 ≤ 800 µm³

Stephanodiscus	81%
Cyclotella	17%
Achnanthes	1%
Fragilaria	1%
Nitzschia	0%

+ 9 more



Diatoms, large

Di2 > 800 µm³ or colonial

Fragilaria	50%
Stephanodiscus	15%
Asterionella	14%
Cyclotella	10%
Tabellaria	4%

+ 18 more

Top genera by share of biovolume, IGKB 1975–2022

Which genera? Phytoplankton (2/2)



Gold algae, small

Go1 ≤ 250 µm³

Erkenia	63%
Chrysochromulina	23%
Chromulina	4%
Ochromonas	2%
Pseudokephyrion	2%

+ 13 more



Gold algae, large

Go2 > 250 µm³ or colonial

Dinobryon	42%
Mallomonas	17%
Uroglena	12%
Chrysophyceae	12%
Pseudopedinella	6%

+ 9 more



Cryptophytes, small

Cr1 ≤ 700 µm³

Rhodomonas	99%
Plagioselmis	1%
Cyathomonas	0%
Cryptaulax	0%
Chilomonas	0%

+ 1 more



Cryptophytes, large

Cr2 > 700 µm³

Cryptomonas	100%
other Cryptophyceen	0%

Top genera by share of biovolume, IGKB 1975–2022

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Figure of Lake Constance (map, phosphorus, temperature): D. Straile, University of Konstanz. Data: IGKB, IBKF.